CULTURE & CUISINE

Restaurants and cafés housed within monuments, art galleries and cultural institutions across India offer a vibrant tapestry of history, tradition and local flavour

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There's nothing quite like stumbling upon a time capsule—particularly when discovering a destination. Monuments, art galleries and historical buildings form an intrinsic part of a city's cultural heritage, whispering secrets of its glorious past. Similarly, the role of cuisine has often been looked at as an expression of cultural identity.

What if both these elements converge to offer a slice of heritage on a plate? This is the newest trend on the block that's taking over Indian cities, with restaurants and cafés increasingly finding shelter inside landmark heritage structures.

Here's a lowdown of some prominent culinary destinations within cultural institutions across India:

DELHI

No conversation about India's capital is complete without a mention of culture and cuisine. Some of the most iconic heritage structures in the country—from the Red Fort to the Qutub Minar, Humayun's Tomb to India Gate—give the city its character. Unsurprisingly, Delhi's love for food also weaves its way into culture, with many cafés and restaurants reflecting the richness of its past.

A shining example of this concept is Café Delhi Heights set within the iconic Red Fort. It is claimed to be India's first restaurant to have opened inside the premises of a national monument. With minimal seating and subtle décor, the team has attempted to preserve the original setting without tampering with its history.

Another popular spot for Delhi's heritage lovers is Sunder Nursery (adjacent to Humayun's Tomb) that houses the city's first arboretum. Here, Fabcafe by the Lake takes centre stage with its vibrant patio umbrellas and lakeside view. From fluffy idlis to baked samosas, gluten-free desserts to momos, there's something for everyone.

Some culinary concepts have also found space in lesser-known monuments as part of their revival and redevelopment. Café Stone (aka the Garden Café) in the Mehrauli Archaeological Park is one such that offers sweeping views of the Qutub Minar. Come with friends or family to enjoy a steaming cuppa or a scrumptious meal with a slice of heritage.

The city's art houses serve as equally thriving spaces for all-day diners. Diggin and L'Opera in Bikaner House always teem with patrons savouring vintage décor paired with comfort food.

There's also the National Gallery of Modern Art that now has three dining options for guests who want to grab a bite between exhibitions. While Amoda serves Indian cuisine, Saddle House is known for Pan-Asian and Continental Fare. Don't forget Green Lane for its elevated street food.

